

[Home](#) > [Catholic Encyclopedia](#) > [T](#) > St. Thomas Becket

St. Thomas Becket

[Please help support the mission of New Advent and get the full contents of this website as an instant download. Includes the Catholic Encyclopedia, Church Fathers, Summa, Bible and more — all for only \\$19.99...](#)

[Martyr](#), [Archbishop](#) of [Canterbury](#), born at [London](#), 21 December, 1118 (?); died at [Canterbury](#), 29 December, 1170. St. Thomas was born of [parents](#) who, coming from [Normandy](#), had settled in [England](#) some years previously. No reliance can be placed upon the [legend](#) that his mother was a [Saracen](#). In after life his [humble](#) birth was made the subject of spiteful comment, though his [parents](#) were not peasants, but people of some mark, and from his earliest years their son had been well taught and had associated with gentlefolk. He learned to read at Merton Abbey and then studied in [Paris](#). On leaving [school](#) he employed himself in secretarial work, first with Sir Richer de l'Aigle and then with his kinsman, Osbert Huitdeniers, who was "Justiciar" of [London](#). Somewhere about the year 1141, under circumstances that are variously related, he entered the service of [Theobald](#), [Archbishop](#) of [Canterbury](#), and in that household he won his master's favour and eventually became the most trusted of all his clerks. A description embodied in the Icelandic Saga and derived probably from Robert of Cricklade gives a vivid portrait of him at this period.

To look upon he was slim of growth and pale of hue, with dark hair, a long nose, and a straightly featured face. Blithe of countenance was he, winning and loveable in his conversation, frank of speech in his discourses, but slightly stuttering in his talk, so keen of discernment and understanding that he could always make difficult questions plain after a wise manner.



Theobald recognized his capacity, made use of him in many delicate negotiations, and, after allowing him to go for a year to study [civil](#) and [canon law](#) at [Bologna](#) and Auxerre, [ordained](#) him [deacon](#) in 1154, after bestowing upon him several preferments, the most important of which was the [Archdeaconry](#) of [Canterbury](#) (see Radford, "Thomas of London", p. 53).

It was just at this period that King Stephen died and the young monarch [Henry II](#) became unquestioned master of the kingdom. He took "Thomas of London", as Becket was then most commonly called, for his chancellor, and in that office Thomas at the age of thirty-six became, with the possible exception of the justiciar, the most powerful subject in [Henry's](#) wide dominions. The chroniclers speak with wonder of the relations which existed between the chancellor and the sovereign, who was twelve years his junior. People declared that "they had but one heart and one mind". Often the king and his minister behaved like two schoolboys at play. But although they [hunted](#) or rode at the head of an army together it was no mere comradeship in pastime which united them. Both were hard workers, and both, we may believe, had the prosperity of the kingdom deeply at heart. Whether the chancellor, who was after all the elder man, was the [true](#) originator of the administrative reforms which [Henry](#) introduced cannot now be clearly determined. In many matters they saw eye to eye. The king's imperial views and [love](#) of splendour were quite to the taste of his minister. When Thomas went to [France](#) in 1158 to negotiate a [marriage](#) treaty, he travelled with such pomp that the people said: "If this be only the chancellor what must be the glory of the king himself?"

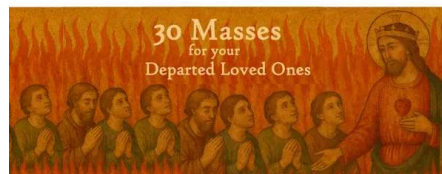
In 1153 Thomas acted as [justice](#) itinerant in three counties. In 1159 he seems to have been the chief organizer of [Henry's](#) expedition to [Toulouse](#), upon which he accompanied him, and though it seems to be [untrue](#) that the impost of "scutage" was called into existence for that occasion (Round, "Feudal England", 268-73), still Thomas undoubtedly pressed on the exaction of this money contribution in lieu of military service and enforced it against [ecclesiastics](#) in such a way that bitter complaints were made of the disproportionately heavy burden this imposed upon the [Church](#). In the military operations Thomas took a leading part, and [Garnier](#), a French chronicler, who lived to write of the virtues of St. Thomas and his [martyrdom](#), declares that in these encounters he saw him unhorse many [French knights](#). [Deacon](#) though he was, he led the most daring attacks in person, and Edward Grim also gives us to understand that in laying waste the enemy's country with fire and sword the chancellor's principles did not materially differ from those of the other commanders of his time. But although, as men then reported, "he put off the [archdeacon](#)", in this and other ways, he was very far from assuming the licentious manners of those around him. No word was ever breathed against his personal purity. Foul conduct or foul speech, lying or unchastity were [hateful](#) to him, and on occasion he punished them severely. He seems at all times to have had clear principles with regard to the claims of the [Church](#), and even during this period of his chancellorship he more than once risked [Henry's](#) grievous displeasure. For example, he opposed the [dispensation](#) which [Henry](#) for political reasons extorted from the [pope](#), and strove to prevent the marriage of Mary, [Abbess](#) of Romsey, to

Matthew of Boulogne. But to the very limits of what his [conscience](#) permitted, Thomas identified himself with his master's interests, and Tennyson is [true](#) to history when he makes the [archbishop](#) say:

I served our [Theobald](#) well when I was with him:
I served [King Henry](#) well as Chancellor:
I am his no more, and I must serve the [Church](#).

[Archbishop Theobald](#) died in 1161, and in the course of the next year [Henry](#) seems to have decided that it would be good policy to prepare the way for further schemes of reform by securing the advancement of his chancellor to the primacy. Our authorities are agreed that from the first Thomas drew back in alarm. "I [know](#) your plans for the [Church](#)," he said, "you will assert claims which I, if I were [archbishop](#), must needs oppose." But [Henry](#) would not be gainsaid, and Thomas at the instance of Cardinal Henry of [Pisa](#), who urged it upon him as a service to religion, yielded in spite of his misgivings. He was [ordained priest](#) on Saturday in [Whitweek](#) and [consecrated bishop](#) the next day, Sunday, 3 June, 1162. It seems to have been St. Thomas who obtained for [England](#) the privilege of keeping the feast of the [Blessed Trinity](#) on that Sunday, the anniversary of his [consecration](#), and more than a century afterwards this custom was adopted by the [papal](#) Court, itself and eventually imposed on the whole world.

Have 30 Masses said for the Poor Souls in Purgatory



A great change took place in the [saint's](#) way of life after his [consecration](#) as [archbishop](#). Even as chancellor he had practised secret austerities, but now in view of the struggle he clearly saw before him he gave himself to fastings and disciplines, [hair shirts](#), protracted vigils, and constant [prayers](#). Before the end of the year 1162 he stripped himself of all signs of the lavish display which he had previously affected. On 10 Aug. he went barefoot to receive the envoy who brought him the [pallium](#) from [Rome](#). Contrary to the king's wish he resigned the chancellorship. Whereupon [Henry](#) seems to have required him to surrender certain [ecclesiastical](#) preferments which he still retained, notably the archdeaconry, and when this was not done at once showed bitter displeasure. Other misunderstandings soon followed. The [archbishop](#), having, as he believed, the king's express permission, set about to reclaim alienated estates belonging to his [see](#), a procedure which again gave offence. Still more serious was the open resistance which he made to the king's proposal that a [voluntary](#) offering to the sheriffs should be paid into the royal treasury. As the first recorded instance of any determined opposition to the king's arbitrary will in a matter of taxation, the incident is of much constitutional importance. The saint's protest seems to have been successful, but the relations with the king only grew more strained.

Soon after this the great matter of dispute was reached in the resistance made by Thomas to the king's officials when they attempted to assert [jurisdiction](#) over criminous clerks. The question has been dealt with in some detail in the article [ENGLAND](#). That the [saint](#) himself had no wish to be lenient with criminous clerks has been well shown by Norgate (*Angevin Kings*, ii, 22). It was with him simply a question of principle. [St. Thomas](#) seems all along to have suspected [Henry](#) of a design to strike at the independence of what the king regarded as a too powerful Church. With this view [Henry](#) summoned the [bishops](#) at [Westminster](#) (1 October, 1163) to sanction certain as yet unspecified articles which he called his grandfather's customs (*avite consuetudines*), one of the known objects of which was to bring [clerics](#) guilty of crimes under the [jurisdiction](#) of the secular courts. The other [bishops](#), as the demand was still in the vague, showed a willingness to submit, though with the condition "saving our order", upon which St. Thomas inflexibly insisted. The king's resentment was thereupon manifested by requiring the [archbishop](#) to surrender certain castles he had hitherto retained, and by other acts of unfriendliness. In deference to what he believed to be the [pope's](#) wish, the [archbishop](#) in December consented to make some concessions by giving a personal and private undertaking to the king to obey his customs "loyally and in [good faith](#)". But when [Henry](#) shortly afterwards at Clarendon (13 January, 1164) sought to draw the [saint](#) on to a formal and public acceptance of the "Constitutions of Clarendon", under which name the sixteen articles, the *avite consuetudines* as finally drafted, have been commonly known, St. Thomas, though at first yielding somewhat to the solicitations of the other [bishops](#), in the end took up an attitude of uncompromising resistance.

Then followed a period of unworthy and vindictive [persecution](#). When opposing a claim made against him by John the Marshal, Thomas upon a frivolous pretext was found guilty of contempt of court. For this he was sentenced to pay £500; other demands for large sums of money followed, and finally, though a complete release of all claims against him as chancellor had been given on his becoming [archbishop](#), he was required to render an account of nearly all the moneys which had passed through his hands in his discharge of the office. Eventually a sum of nearly £30,000 was demanded of him. His fellow [bishops](#) summoned by [Henry](#) to a council at [Northampton](#), implored him to throw himself unreservedly upon the king's mercy, but St. Thomas, instead of yielding, solemnly warned them and threatened them. Then, after celebrating [Mass](#), he took his [archiepiscopal](#) cross into his own hand and presented himself thus in the royal council chamber. The king demanded that sentence should be passed upon him, but in the confusion and discussion which ensued the [saint](#) with uplifted cross made his way through the mob of angry courtiers. He fled away secretly that night (13 October, 1164), sailed in disguise from Sandwich (2 November), and after being cordially welcomed by Louis VII of [France](#), he threw himself at the feet of [Pope Alexander III](#), then at [Sens](#), on 23 Nov. The [pope](#), who had given a cold reception to certain episcopal envoys sent by [Henry](#), welcomed the [saint](#) very kindly, and refused to accept his resignation of his [see](#). On 30 November, Thomas went to take up his residence at the [Cistercian Abbey of Pontigny](#) in [Burgundy](#), though he was compelled to leave this refuge a year later, as [Henry](#), after confiscating the [archbishop's](#) [property](#) and banishing all the Becket kinsfolk, threatened to wreak his vengeance on the whole [Cistercian Order](#) if they continued to harbour him.

The negotiations between [Henry](#), the [pope](#), and the [archbishop](#) dragged on for the next four years without the position being sensibly changed. Although the [saint](#) remained firm in his resistance to the principle of the Constitutions of Clarendon, he was willing to make any concessions that could be reasonably asked of him, and on 6 January, 1169, when the kings of [England](#) and [France](#) were in conference at Montmirail, he threw himself at [Henry's](#) feet, but as he still refused to accept the obnoxious customs [Henry](#) repulsed him. At last in 1170 some sort of reconciliation was patched up. The question of the customs was not mentioned and [Henry](#) professed himself willing to be guided by the [archbishop's](#) council as to amends due to the [See of Canterbury](#) for the recent violation of its [rights](#) in the crowning of [Henry's](#) son by the [Archbishop](#) of [York](#). On 1 December, 1170, St. Thomas again landed in England, and was received with every demonstration of popular enthusiasm. But trouble almost immediately occurred in connection with the absolution of two of the bishops, whose sentence of excommunication St. Thomas had brought with him, as well as over the

restoration by the de Broc [family](#) of the [archbishop's](#) castle at Saltwood. How far [Henry](#) was directly responsible for the tragedy which soon after occurred on 29 December is not quite clear. Four [knights](#) who came from [France](#) demanded the [absolution](#) of the [bishops](#). St. Thomas would not comply. They left for a space, but came back at Vesper time with a band of armed men. To their angry question, "Where is the traitor?" the [saint](#) boldly replied, "Here I am, no traitor, but [archbishop](#) and [priest](#) of [God](#)." They tried to drag him from the church, but were unable, and in the end they slew him where he stood, scattering his brains on the pavement. His faithful companion, Edward Grim, who bore his cross, was wounded in the struggle.

A tremendous reaction of feeling followed this deed of blood. In an extraordinary brief space of time devotion to the [martyred archbishop](#) had spread all through [Europe](#). The [pope](#) [promulgated](#) the bull of [canonization](#), little more than two years after the [martyrdom](#), 21 February, 1173. On 12 July, 1174, [Henry II](#) did public penance, and was scourged at the [archbishop's tomb](#). An immense number of [miracles](#) were worked, and for the rest of the [Middle Ages](#) the shrine of St. Thomas of Canterbury was one of the wealthiest and most famous in [Europe](#). The [martyr's](#) holy remains are believed to have been destroyed in September, 1538, when nearly all the other shrines in [England](#) were dismantled; but the matter is by no means clear, and, although the weight of learned opinion is adverse, there are still those who believe that a skeleton found in the [crypt](#) in January, 1888, is the body of St. Thomas. The story that [Henry VIII](#) in 1538 summoned the [archbishop](#) to stand his trial for high treason, and that when, in June, 1538, the trial had been held and the accused pronounced contumacious, the body was ordered to be disinterred and burnt, is probably [apocryphal](#).

	How To Drain Lymph Fluid In Ankles & Legs Naturally? Lemena	Open
---	--	-----------------------------

Sources

By far the best English life is MORRIS, *The Life of St. Thomas Becket* (2nd ed., London, 1885); there is a somewhat fuller work of L'HUILLIER, *Saint Thomas de Cantorbery* (2 vols., Paris, 1891); the volume by DEMIMUID, *St. Thomas Becket* (Paris, 1909), in the series *Les Saints* is not abreast of modern research. There are several excellent lives by Anglicans, of which HUTTON, *Thomas Becket* (London, 1900), and the account by NORGATE in *Dict. Nat. Biog.*, s.v. Thomas, known as Thomas a Becket, are probably the best. The biography by ROBERTSON, *Becket, Archbishop of Canterbury* (London, 1859), is not sympathetic. Nearly all the sources of the Life, as well as the books of miracles worked at the shrine, have been edited in the *Rolls Series* by ROBERTSON under the title *Materials for the History of Thomas Becket* (7 vols., London, 1875-1883). The valuable Norse saga is edited in the same series by MAGNUSSON, *Thomas Saga Erkebyskups* (2 vols., London, 1884). The chronicle of GARNIER DE PONT S. MAXENCE, *Vie de St. Thomas Martyr*, has been edited by HIPPEAU (Paris, 1859). The miracles have been specially studied from an agnostic standpoint by ABBOT, *Thomas of Canterbury, his death and miracles* (2 vols., London, 1898). Some valuable material has been collected by RADFORD, *Thomas of London before his Consecration* (Cambridge, 1894). On the relics see MORRIS, *Relics of St. Thomas* (London, 1888); THORNTON, *Becket's Bones* (Canterbury, 1900); WARD, *The Canterbury Pilgrimages* (London, 1904); WARNER in *Eng. Hist. Rev.*, VI (1891), 754-56.

About this page



APA citation. Thurston, H. (1912). St. Thomas Becket. In *The Catholic Encyclopedia*. New York: Robert Appleton Company.
<https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/14676a.htm>

MLA citation. Thurston, Herbert. "St. Thomas Becket." *The Catholic Encyclopedia*. Vol. 14. New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1912.
 <<https://www.newadvent.org/cathen/14676a.htm>>.

Transcription. This article was transcribed for New Advent by Thomas M. Barrett. St. Thomas Becket, pray for us.

Ecclesiastical approbation. *Nihil Obstat*. July 1, 1912. Remy Lafort, S.T.D., Censor. *Imprimatur*. +John Cardinal Farley, Archbishop of New York.

Contact information. The editor of New Advent is Kevin Knight. My email address is webmaster *at* newadvent.org. Regrettably, I can't reply to every letter, but I greatly appreciate your feedback — especially notifications about typographical errors and inappropriate ads.

Copyright © 2026 by [New Advent LLC](#). Dedicated to the Immaculate Heart of Mary.

[CONTACT US](#) | [ADVERTISE WITH NEW ADVENT](#)

